$(\mathcal{LC})^2$: LEARNING CONSTANT-SIZE LATENT CONTEXT FOR LANGUAGE MODEL AGENTS

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ABSTRACT

Language model agents have become highly capable across many areas. They accumulate increasingly long contexts of observations, actions, tool outputs, and intermediate reasoning. Without proper context management, the performance of agents can degrade significantly as the context grows. Another major problem is that long context can drive costs up, making language model agents prohibitive in practice. In this work, we ask: *can we effectively compress the agent context without affecting its performance?* In this work, we propose $(\mathcal{LC})^2$: a framework for **l**earning a **c**onstant-size **l**atent **c**ontext for a *frozen* language model agent. We leverage the representational capacity of the model's continuous latent token space: *even as the rounds of agent interaction increase, the number of (latent) tokens representing the context remains constant*. Concretely, we train a lightweight compressor to compress past context history into a constant number of latent tokens that we insert directly into the frozen language model's embedding sequence. We use a two-stage training procedure: behavioral supervised learning first teaches the compressor to preserve the full context, followed by reinforcement learning that directly optimizes the compressor using the downstream task reward. We argue that this training procedure can learn a compact latent representation of an agent's context, rather than relying on pure natural-language text summarization. Results on three widely used agentic benchmarks show that our method can improve performance up to 10% while reducing the token count to one-tenth of the original.

1 INTRODUCTION

Recently, language model agents (Su et al., 2024; Schick et al., 2023; Yao et al., 2023; Schick et al., 2023), built on large language models (LLMs), have become increasingly capable in many areas such as web navigation (Deng et al., 2023; Zhou et al., 2024), information seeking (Nakano et al., 2021; Yao et al., 2023), and deep research (Zheng et al., 2025; Li et al., 2025). The most widely used agentic paradigm is ReAct (Yao et al., 2023), where agents interact with the external environment, invoke tools, observe outputs, and reason about actions turn by turn. Unlike conventional single-turn language modeling, an agent's decision at each turn is conditioned on an evolving *context* consisting of previous turns' observations, actions, tool outputs, and intermediate reasoning.

As a result, context grows continuously with the number of turns, causing several issues. *First*, the growing context significantly increases the inference cost. *Second*, the growing context may exceed the language model's context window, causing the agent to lose information from earlier turns. *Third*, even if the context stays within the language model's context window, prior work shows that the effective context window is much smaller than the physical context window[1], a phenomenon known as *context rot* (Hong et al., 2025; Liu et al., 2024). Context rot will significantly degrade agents' performance. As such, effective context management for language model agents has become an important research question. The challenge is to manage the context such that the agent can make the right decisions.

[1]By physical context window, we mean the context window length determined by the model architecture.

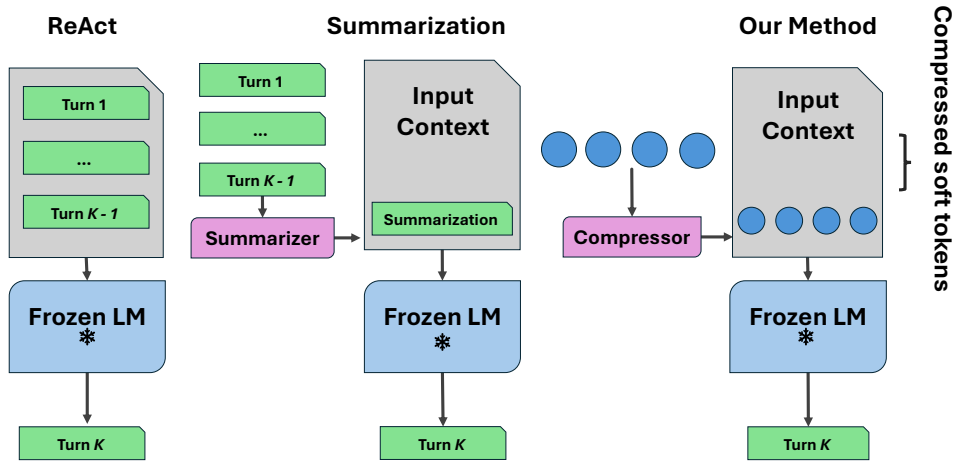


FIGURE 1: Comparison of three representative methods for agent context management. **Left**: ReAct Agent, where the agent concatenates all previous history. This causes the context to explode quickly, and the model struggles to extract useful information from the long context; additionally, processing the long context is expensive. **Middle**: Summarization Agent, where the agent summarizes all previous turns' context. However, the summarization heuristics are usually manually designed and ignore task requirements. There is no guarantee that the summarized information is useful for future decision-making. **Right**: Our method. In each turn, we strictly maintain a constant-size latent token set, which dramatically reduces the inference cost. Moreover, we learn to preserve information for future decision-making via compressed soft tokens. This design combines the best of both worlds in ReAct-style agents and summarization-style agents.

Existing approaches for agent context management (Wu et al., 2025; Ye et al., 2025; Sun et al., 2025), however, operate predominantly in the **natural-language space**: they select, discard, rewrite, or retrieve past interactions into shorter textual contexts, based on either heuristics, optimization algorithms, or other language model agents, which could introduce additional token costs. In contrast, another line of research has explored compressing long contexts into **latent token representations**. Gisting (Mu et al., 2023), AutoCompressors (Chevalier et al., 2023), and ICAE (Ge et al., 2024), for example, represent long textual inputs using learned latent tokens or vectors. While these studies show the potential of latent tokens for context representations, they focus on compressing prompts, documents, or conventional language-model contexts rather than the agent setting. This raises a natural research question: ***Can we compress the agent context effectively without affecting its performance?***

Representing the context in latent token space is more appealing because, in theory, continuous latent tokens can store much more information than the same number of discrete tokens. However, directly representing agent context in latent token space is not without its challenges: Unlike single-turn context representation, the agent context is *dynamic* and *stateful*; each turn's new context (including observations, actions, reasoning, etc) is conditioned on the previous context representation. Moreover, single-turn context representation focuses on preserving the semantic information of the context, while a good agent context representation should preserve the information that best facilitates future agent actions. These fundamentally different goals may lead to different decisions about which pieces of information to select and which to discard.

In this work, we introduce $(\mathcal{LC})^2$: a framework that **L**earns **C**onstant-size **L**atent **C**ontext for language model agents. See Figure 1 for an overview. We train a separate lightweight model, a compressor, to compress the agent's accumulated context into a constant number K of latent tokens, while keeping the original language model frozen. We insert the latent tokens directly into the frozen language model's input embedding sequence. Crucially, K is **independent of the number of turns**: while the raw interaction context continually grows with the number of turns, the latent context representation remains constant. Furthermore, we freeze the language model and use a separate compressor for context management. This modular design substantially reduces training cost,

preserves the underlying language model's capabilities, and lets us optimize the latent representation specifically for downstream agent behavior. We train the compressor in two stages: behavior supervised learning followed by reinforcement learning. We show that these two stages complement each other, and that neither is redundant via ablation experiments.

We evaluate $(\mathcal{LC})^2$on three representative agent benchmarks: `ALFWorld` (Shridhar et al., 2021), `Webshop` (Yao et al., 2022), and `HotpotQA` (Yang et al., 2018). Our method achieves on-par or better performance than many context management methods while significantly reducing token cost. Further analyses show that $(\mathcal{LC})^2$is also effective for long-horizon settings, that both training stages are important, and that the constant K mediate the trade-off between representation capacity and generalization.

2 Related Work

Agent Context Management. Language model agents accumulate observations, actions, tool outputs, and intermediate reasoning into the context, which can readily exceed the context limit of the agent. As such, context management becomes essential for agent performance. Some common approaches manage the context in *natural-language space* through heuristic selection, summarization, or hierarchical organization. HiAgent (Hu et al., 2025) organizes the context into hierarchical working memory. It prompts LLMs to formulate and replace subgoals with summarized observations. ACON (Kang et al., 2025) optimizes compression strategies by understanding failures and distilling the updated strategy into smaller compressors. Rather than explicitly summarizing the entire context, PACE (Wei et al., 2026) dynamically adjusts the granularity of the summarization of context information based on its predicted relevance. These approaches show that heuristic-based retention and summarization can substantially shorten the agent's context. However, they may increase the overall token cost if, e.g., another language model is required for summarization.

Another line of work introduces a *separate learned component* for context management. CoMem (Zhang et al., 2026a) decouples context management from language model policy execution through an auxiliary long-context model, which increases cost. AgentFold (Ye et al., 2025) proactively consolidates interaction histories at different granularities, allowing long-horizon web agents to discard intermediate details while preserving information to facilitate future actions. These approaches motivate separating *context management* from *language model policy execution*, but still mainly operate in natural language space.

More recent work directly *learns* context-management. MEM1 (Zhou et al., 2025) jointly learns reasoning and memory consolidation through reinforcement learning, but it requires fine-tuning the language model itself. SUPO (Lu et al., 2025) integrates context summarization into end-to-end agentic RL, jointly optimizing reasoning and context summarization. Similarly, Memory-as-Action (Zhang et al., 2026b) integrates memory-editing operations into the agent action space and optimizes the language model via end-to-end agentic RL. Context-Folding (Sun et al., 2025) designs an RL algorithm to encourage task decomposition and context management. These works shift from *heuristically designed* context management to end-to-end learning of context representations.

Despite different mechanisms, these approaches predominantly expose the compressed context to the language model through *discrete natural-language tokens*. Our work investigates a complementary representation choice: we compress the evolving interaction context into a *constant number of continuous latent tokens*. By training a separate compressor and keeping the language model frozen, our approach retains the modular separation between context compression and language model policy execution.

Latent Representations for Context Compression. Another line of research represents long, non-agentic textual contexts such as prompts and documents with compact, learned latent representations. Gist Tokens (Mu et al., 2023) compress prompts into a small set of learned tokens with modified attention masks. It shows that prompt instructions can be preserved in a "gist" token space. ICAE (Ge et al., 2024) extends this idea to long contexts by compressing text into compact memory slots that a language model can condition on directly. Activation Beacon (Zhang et al., 2025) compresses LLM activations through trainable beacon tokens and enables recurrent processing of contexts beyond the model's context window. xRAG (Cheng et al., 2024) trains a modality bridge, which maps dense retrieval embeddings directly into the LLM representation space. It compresses

documents into a small number of tokens while keeping both the retriever and the language model frozen.

These works show the potential of compact latent representations for long contexts, but primarily focus on *static and stateless prompts and documents*. Agent context, by contrast, is *dynamic and stateful*. Our work bridges these two directions by learning a **constant-size latent representation of an evolving agent context** with a separate compressor, while keeping the language model frozen.

3 METHOD

We propose $(\mathcal{LC})^2$: a framework for **l**earning a **c**onstant-size **l**atent **c**ontext representation for language model agents. We do not concatenate an ever-growing context for each turn. Instead, we train a lightweight compressor $\mathcal{C}_\phi$ to integrate the current turn's new information into a constant number of latent tokens. The compressor itself is a small pre-trained decoder-only transformer.

To achieve this, we introduce K learnable latent tokens $\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{\text{inst}}$ at the compressor input embedding [2]. Intuitively, $\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{\text{inst}}$ represents the instruction to concatenate the previous turn's information with the current turn. We let $\mathbf{Z}$ be the last K token embeddings of the last layer's hidden state of the compressor transformer.

We train a non-linear map to convert the compressor output hidden state into the input embedding of the language model as well as another non-linear map to convert it into the compressor's input embedding The language model Π_θ remains frozen during training. We train the compressor and the two maps using behavior supervised learning followed by reinforcement learning with Group Relative Policy Optimization (GRPO; Shao et al., 2024), with downstream task rewards.

3.1 PROBLEM FORMULATION

We consider a language model agent, backed by the language model policy Π_θ, interacting with an environment ξ. At step t, the agent receives an observation o_t from the environment and generates an action a_t, which may include intermediate reasoning and/or tool calls. We denote each turn's information at step t by h_t, where $h_t = (o_t, a_t)$. We define the raw accumulated context before step t as

$$\mathcal{H}_{<t} = (h_1, \ldots, h_{t-1}).$$

In a ReAct-style agent, we have:

$$a_t \sim \Pi_\theta\left(\cdot \mid \mathcal{H}_{<t}, o_t\right)$$

3.2 METHOD OVERVIEW AND INFERENCE

In this subsection, we describe the inference procedure and provide an overview of our method. We use d_c for the compressor transformer's model dimension and d as the language model's dimension. At step t, we use a compressor to output K latent tokens $\mathbf{Z}_t$. Concretely,

$$\mathbf{Z}_t = \mathcal{C}_\phi\left(\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{t-1}, h_{t-1}, \widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{\text{inst}}\right) \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times d_c} \tag{1}$$

$\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{\text{inst}} \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times d_c}$ are learnable K latent tokens that intuitively represent the instruction to merge previous steps' information and the current step's observation. $\mathbf{Z}_t$ is taken from the last K positions of the last layer's hidden state of the compressor transformer. The compressor transformer's last-layer hidden state is not aligned with the compressor transformer's input embedding or the language model's input embedding. We therefore introduce two learnable non-linear mappers.

- $\mathcal{F}_\omega : \mathbb{R}^{d_c} \to \mathbb{R}^{d_c}$ maps the compressor's last layer hidden state back to its input embedding.

$$\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_t = \mathcal{F}_\omega\left(\mathbf{Z}_t\right) \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times d_c} \tag{2}$$

- $\mathcal{P}_\psi : \mathbb{R}^{d_c} \to \mathbb{R}^{d}$ maps the compressor's last layer hidden state to the language model's input embedding.

$$\widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}_t = \mathcal{P}_\psi\left(\mathbf{Z}_t\right) \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times d} \tag{3}$$

[2] We use $\mathbf{Z}$ to represent the hidden state at the compressor transformer's last layer, $\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}$ to represent latent tokens in the compressor's input, and $\widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}$ to represent latent tokens in the target language model's input.

a_t is then sampled as:

$$a_t \sim \Pi_\theta \left(\cdot \mid \widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}_t, o_t \right) \tag{4}$$

In summary, at step t, the inference procedure is as follows:

$$\boxed{\begin{aligned} \mathbf{Z}_t &= \mathcal{C}_\phi \left(\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{t-1}, h_{t-1}, \widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{\text{inst}} \right) \\ \widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_t &= \mathcal{F}_\omega \left(\mathbf{Z}_t \right) \\ \widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}_t &= \mathcal{P}_\psi \left(\mathbf{Z}_t \right) \\ a_t &\sim \Pi_\theta \left(\cdot \mid \widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}_t, o_t \right) \end{aligned}} \tag{5}$$

Non-linear mapper details. $\mathcal{F}_\omega$ and $\mathcal{P}_\psi$ are learnable shallow nonlinear token-wise mappers.

Each mapper is a 2-layer MLP with layer normalization:

$$M(\mathbf{x}) = W_2 \sigma \left(W_1 \, \mathrm{LN}(\mathbf{x}) + b_1 \right) + b_2,$$

where LN is layer normalization (Ba et al., 2016) and σ is a non-linear activation function; we choose GELU (Hendrycks & Gimpel, 2016). The two maps have independent parameters.

Algorithm 1 summarizes the inference procedure.

3.3 Behavior Supervised Learning

Directly training the compressor with reinforcement learning is challenging because RL provides little signal for learning the context representation, especially early during training. As such, we bootstrap by first using behavior supervised learning. In this stage, we train the compressor to mimic the behavior of a ReAct-style trajectory. Concretely,

Let

$$\tau^* = (o_1, a_1^*, \ldots, o_T, a_T^*)$$

be a successful trajectory from dataset $\mathcal{D}$ filtered by advanced models. During training, at each step t, we teacher-force the demonstrated action a_{t-1}^*. We want the frozen language model to reproduce the demonstrated action; thus, we design the loss function for the behavior supervised learning as follows:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{BSL}} = -\mathbb{E}_{\tau^* \sim \mathcal{D}} \left[\sum_{t=1}^{T} \log \Pi_\theta \left(a_t^* \mid \mathcal{P}_\psi(\mathbf{Z}_t), o_t \right) \right]. \tag{6}$$

For an autoregressive action $a_t^* = (y_{t,1}^*, \ldots, y_{t,L_t}^*)$, where L_t is the token length of a_t, the likelihood can be further decomposed as:

$$\log \Pi_\theta \left(a_t^* \mid \mathcal{P}_\psi(\mathbf{Z}_t), o_t \right) = \sum_{l=1}^{L_t} \log \Pi_\theta \left(y_{t,l}^* \mid \mathcal{P}_\psi(\mathbf{Z}_t), o_t, y_{t,<l}^* \right). \tag{7}$$

The language model parameters θ remain frozen. Gradients propagate through the language model into the compressor and the non-linear mappers. The trainable parameters are therefore

$$\Theta = \{\phi, \omega, \psi, \widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{\text{inst}}\}. \tag{8}$$

We optimize

$$\Theta \leftarrow \Theta - \eta \nabla_\Theta \left[\frac{1}{|\mathcal{B}_k|} \sum_{i \in \mathcal{B}_k} \mathcal{L}_{\text{BSL}}^{(i)} \right]. \tag{9}$$

where $\mathcal{B}_k$ is a mini-batch. Algorithm 2 summarizes this training stage.

3.4 Optimizing the Compressor via Task Reward using Reinforcement Learning

After behavior supervised learning, we further train the compressor directly with GRPO (Shao et al., 2024) using trajectory-level task rewards. The trainable parameters are the same and are initialized from behavior supervised learning (i.e., $\Theta^{*}_{\mathrm{BSL}} = \Theta^{(0)}_{\mathrm{GRPO}}$).

For each task instance x, we sample a group of G trajectories $\{\tau_i\}_{i=1}^{G}$ using the current compressor and frozen language model. Each trajectory is independent of the others. Upon termination, trajectory τ_i receives task reward R_i. We compute its group-relative advantage as

$$\widehat{A}_i = \frac{R_i - \mu_R}{\sigma_R + \delta}, \qquad \mu_R = \frac{1}{G}\sum_{j=1}^{G} R_j, \tag{10}$$

where σ_R is the standard deviation of rewards within the group and $\delta > 0$ is a small constant for numerical stability.

For token $y_{i,t,l}$ [3], define

$$p_\Theta(y_{i,t,l}) = \Pi_\theta\Big(y_{i,t,l} \mid \mathcal{P}_\psi(\mathbf{Z}_{i,t}), o_{i,t}, y_{i,t,<l}\Big), \tag{11}$$

where $\mathbf{Z}_{i,t}$ depends on a and is obtained by recurrently applying Eq. 5.

Let Θ^{old} denote the parameters used to generate the rollout. The token-level importance ratio is

$$r_{i,t,l}(\Theta) = \frac{p_\Theta(y_{i,t,l})}{p_{\Theta^{\mathrm{old}}}(y_{i,t,l})}. \tag{12}$$

We then optimize the clipped GRPO objective

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{J}_{\mathrm{GRPO}}(\Theta) = \mathbb{E}_{i,t,l}\Big[\min\big(&r_{i,t,l}(\Theta)\hat{A}_i,\\ &\mathrm{clip}(r_{i,t,l}(\Theta), 1-\varepsilon, 1+\varepsilon)\hat{A}_i\big)\Big],\end{aligned} \tag{13}$$

where ε controls the clipping range. For simplicity, we ignore the KL regularization term.

Truncated gradient propagation. The recurrent nature of $\mathbf{Z}_t$ creates a gradient dependency chain, similar to that in an RNN. In practice, especially in long-horizon interactions, we observe some training instability due to this effect. To remedy this, we use Truncated Backpropagation Through Time (TBPTT; Williams & Peng, 1990), where the gradient dependency can span at most M_{TBPTT} steps. In mathematical terms,

$$\mathbf{Z}_t \to \mathbf{Z}_{t+1} \to \cdots \to \mathbf{Z}_{t+M_{\mathrm{TBPTT}}}, \qquad \mathrm{stopgrad}(\mathbf{Z}_{t+M_{\mathrm{TBPTT}}}). \tag{14}$$

The truncation affects only gradient propagation. The forward computation does not change. Algorithm 3 summarizes the RL stage.

4 Experiments

We evaluate our method on three representative agentic benchmarks: **ALFWorld** (Shridhar et al., 2021), **WebShop** (Yao et al., 2022), and **HotpotQA** (Yang et al., 2018), emulating an embodied intelligence environment, a web shopping environment, and a search-based QA environment, respectively. Our experiments aim to answer the following research questions: (1) How well does our method perform, both in terms of task accuracy and token efficiency? (2) How does the number of latent tokens K affect in-distribution and out-of-distribution performance? (3) How well does our method perform under long-horizon scenarios? (4) How much does each training stage contribute to overall performance?

[3] lth token at step t in trajectory i

4.1 EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

Benchmarks. We evaluate on **ALFWorld**, **WebShop**, and **HotpotQA**. **ALFWorld** is a text-based interactive embodied environment with six task types and two evaluation settings: seen tasks with in-distribution environments and unseen tasks with out-of-distribution environments. **WebShop** is a text-based simulated web shopping environment, and the agent's task is to navigate webpages to achieve the goals specified in the query. **HotpotQA** is a multi-step question-answering benchmark where the agent can use search tools to answer questions.

Metrics. For **ALFWorld**, we use success rate as the performance metric, where 1 represents the agent successfully completing the task. For **WebShop**, we use the reward score as the performance metric. The agent can get partial scores even if it does not complete the task perfectly. For **HotpotQA**, we report both exact match accuracy (EM) and F1. All reported numbers are re-scaled to 1-100 for better readability.

Baselines. We compare our method against three representative context management methods. (1) **ReAct** (Yao et al., 2023), where at each turn, the context simply concatenates the previous turn's history. (2) **Sliding window** is a widely used context management method in practice, where the method maintains a fixed context budget. If the context exceeds the budget, it discards older history. (3) **Summarization** (Wu et al., 2025), which periodically summarizes the context by calling another agent. We report additional details and parameters for our method and the baselines in Appendix B.

4.2 MAIN RESULTS

TABLE 1: Main results on **ALFWorld**, **WebShop**, and **HotpotQA**. We report success rates on the seen and unseen splits of **ALFWorld**, task score on **WebShop**, and exact match (EM) and F1 on **HotpotQA**. Tokens denote the average number of input tokens for the evaluation. Higher task performance and lower token consumption are better. We **highlight** the best result and underline the second-best result.

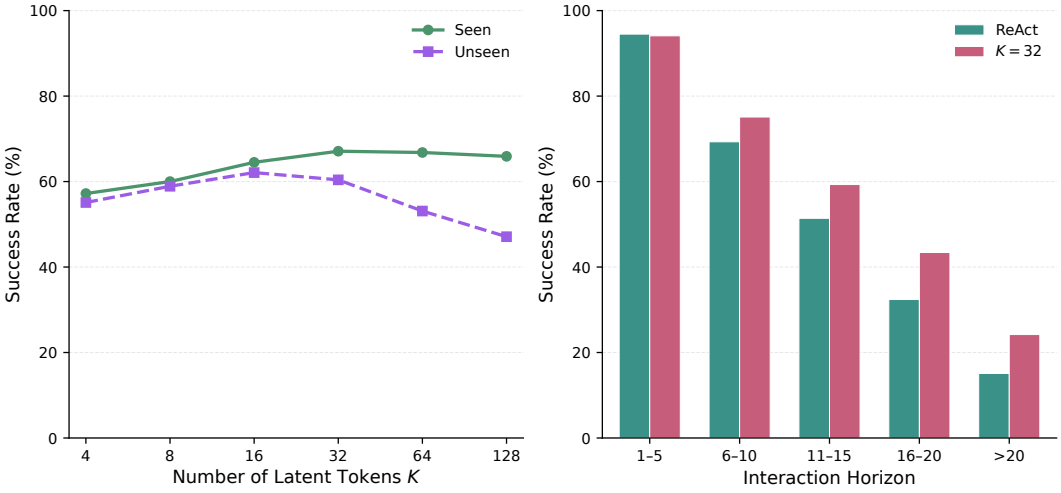
	ALFWorld			WebShop		HotpotQA		
Method	Seen ↑	Unseen ↑	Tokens ↓	Score ↑	Tokens ↓	EM ↑	F1 ↑	Tokens ↓
ReAct	59.5	52.1	23.1M	46.2	9.5M	<u>34.1</u>	<u>37.7</u>	3.3M
Sliding Window	43.1	39.9	6.7M	33.1	2.1M	29.1	33.4	1.9M
Summarization	53.4	50.0	3.2M	41.7	1.9M	32.1	35.4	2.0M
$(\mathcal{LC})^2 (K = 16)$	<u>64.5</u>	**62.1**	**1.5M**	<u>50.9</u>	**0.8M**	33.0	35.7	**0.3M**
$(\mathcal{LC})^2 (K = 32)$	**67.1**	<u>60.4</u>	<u>1.6M</u>	**51.6**	<u>0.8M</u>	**35.7**	**39.6**	<u>0.4M</u>

Table 1 presents our main results on the three benchmarks. We report both the total number of tokens and the task performance for each method.

In terms of task performance, our methods consistently outperform the ReAct baseline across all three benchmarks. In particular, in the **ALFWorld** *seen* setting, our best method $K = 32$ outperforms ReAct by 7.6%; in the *unseen* setting, our best method $K = 16$ outperforms ReAct by 10.0%. The sliding window method performs poorly on **ALFWorld**. We conjecture that **ALFWorld** has the longest horizon over these three benchmarks, and the sliding window method may miss important context from early interaction histories. Interestingly, we achieve the best result on **ALFWorld** "seen" when $K = 32$, while we achieve the best result on **ALFWorld** "unseen" when $K = 16$. This suggests that although $K = 32$ gives us the best in-distribution performance, $K = 16$ provides better out-of-distribution performance. Choosing K is therefore a trade-off between capability and generalization.

In terms of tokens, our method uses the fewest tokens by design. On average, ReAct uses $10\times$ as many tokens as our method. The sliding window and summarization method also uses far fewer tokens than ReAct. The summarization method generally uses fewer tokens than the sliding window method, except in the **HotpotQA** benchmark. Note that $K = 32$ uses only slightly more tokens than $K = 16$. This suggests that increasing K only moderately increases the token count, and most tokens in our method come from the new information at each turn, which is unavoidable.

In summary, our method achieves the best overall performance among all baselines while significantly reducing the total number of tokens.



(A) Effect of K. (B) Performance across different interaction horizons.

FIGURE 2: (a) Success rate of seen and unseen settings in **ALFWorld** across different K. (b) Success rate of $K = 16$ and $K = 32$ across different interaction horizons in **ALFWorld**, aggregated between seen and unseen.

4.3 EFFECT OF K: NUMBER OF LATENT TOKENS

In Table 1, we observe that larger K does not necessarily lead to better unseen performance in **ALFWorld**. We conjecture that large K offers more powerful representation capabilities but may also overfit, leading to worse performance on out-of-distribution (i.e., *unseen*) tasks. To analyze this further and quantify the trade-off between capacity and generalization, we test values of K from 4 to 128 and compare performance on *seen* and *unseen* portions of **ALFWorld**.

As shown in Figure 2a, for performance on the *seen* examples, $K = 32$ yields the best among all values. Smaller K may lack the representational power to learn the training data, while larger K may overfit to the training data. In practice, the performance of larger K plateaus on the *seen* examples. However, on *unseen* examples, the story is different. The optimal K shifts from 32 to 16. Although smaller K generally remains suboptimal, larger K degrades performance significantly. This shows that larger K overfits significantly to the seen training data and generalizes poorly.

Overall, this study shows that the choice of K has profound implications: smaller K may result in insufficient representation capacity, but larger K may generalize poorly. An ideal value of K has sufficient representational capacity while simultaneously providing good generalization.

4.4 PERFORMANCE VERSUS INTERACTION HORIZON

As the interaction horizon increases (i.e., the number of interaction turns), the context that needs to be represented also grows significantly. As such, a natural question arises: how does our method perform under different interaction horizons? Since **ALFWorld** has the longest interaction horizon, we mainly use **ALFWorld** for analysis in this section. To answer this question, we group the completed trajectories in Table 1 according to intervals of interaction horizons and show the results in Figure 2b. We show the result for both $K = 32$ and ReAct in a side-by-side comparison, in order to discern whether poor performance over long horizons is due to the model itself or due to our method.

As shown in Figure 2b, both methods' performance drops roughly linearly as the interaction horizon increases. However, in the long-horizon regime, our method does not worsen relative to ReAct. In the short-horizon regime, our method performs similarly to ReAct. The performance drop in the

long-horizon regime is due to the model or the agent's internal capabilities, not due to our method per se.

4.5 Ablation Study of Different Training Stages

TABLE 2: Ablation of different training stages. We compare behavior supervised learning (BSL) only, reinforcement learning (RL) only, and the full two-stage training approaches in **ALFWorld** when $K = 32$, aggregated between seen and unseen.

Training Methodology	ALFWorld
BSL only	55.6
RL only	51.4
BSL $\rightarrow$ RL	**63.8**

Finally, we conduct ablation studies on the contribution of each training stage. We compare the performance of the complete two-stage training approach versus behavior supervised learning only versus reinforcement learning only. Due to computational constraints, we report results only on **ALFWorld**.

Table 2 shows the results of different training stages. The BSL-only approach roughly matches ReAct. This shows that BSL successfully mimics ReAct's behavior. Interestingly, the reinforcement learning-only approach performs the worst. We conjecture that reinforcement learning provides little signal, especially early during training, for learning the context representation, and leads to training instability and suboptimal performance.

Overall, the two-stage training approach, which starts with behavior supervised learning followed by reinforcement learning, performs the best, and so each training stage is instrumental.

5 Conclusion

In this study, we present $(\mathcal{LC})^2$: a framework that **l**earns **c**onstant-size **l**atent tokens for the **c**ontext of language model agents. During each interaction step, a lightweight compressor maps the current turn's interaction and previous context into a constant number of latent tokens. We freeze the language model and first train the compressor with behavior supervised learning, then fine-tune it with reinforcement learning using downstream task rewards. We evaluate our method on three representative benchmarks, and the results show that it significantly reduces token cost while increasing task performance. We further show that the number of latent tokens provides a trade-off between capability and generalization, and that our method also works in long-horizon settings. Further ablation studies also show that the two training stages complement each other and neither is redundant.

AI use statement

In this work, we used generative AI tools to assist with writing proofs and implementing methods. We have not used generative AI tools to help develop theoretical models or conceptual frameworks, formulate mathematical claims, propose or refine hypotheses, design or provide feedback on research methodology or experiments, support qualitative and thematic data analysis, or interpret results, and generate synthetic datasets, assist with translation, clean and reformat datasets, and provide critical ingredients for proving mathematical claims are not applicable to this work.

Additionally, we used generative AI tools to plot figures and survey the literature. We have reviewed all AI-assisted work. We checked that the LLM-generated code is correct. We checked that the LLM-generated writing is correct. We checked that the literature recommended by LLMs is not hallucinated. We take responsibility for the final content of this work, including text, claims, or artifacts produced with the aid of generative AI.

REPRODUCIBILITY STATEMENT

Our code is available at https://anonymous.4open.science/r/lc2-8F1E/. We describe all details in Section 4.1 and Appendix B.

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A Algorithm Details

See Algorithm 1 for inference, Algorithm 2 for behavior supervised learning, and Algorithm 3 for GRPO reinforcement learning (Shao et al., 2024).

Algorithm 1 Inference Algorithm

Require: Compressor $\mathcal{C}_\phi$; $\mathcal{F}_\omega$ and $\mathcal{P}_\psi$; $\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{\text{inst}}$; frozen language model$\Pi_\theta$; environment ξ

Initialize recurrent state $\mathbf{Z}_1$
Receive initial observation o_1
for $t = 1, 2, \ldots, T$ **do**
  $\widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}_t \leftarrow \mathcal{P}_\psi(\mathbf{Z}_t)$
  $a_t \sim \Pi_\theta(\cdot \mid \widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}_t, o_t)$
  Execute a_t in ξ and receive o_{t+1}
  Construct interaction h_t
  if task terminates **then**
    break
  end if
  $\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_t \leftarrow \mathcal{F}_\omega(\mathbf{Z}_t)$
  $\mathbf{Z}_{t+1} \leftarrow \mathcal{C}_\phi\left(\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_t, h_t, \widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{\text{inst}}\right)$
end for
return final agent output

B Additional Details

B.1 Example Prompts

Below is the prompt template for each benchmark.

B.1.1 ALFWorld

ALFWorld Prompt Template

Task
{task_instruction}
Observation
{current_observation}

Algorithm 2 Behavior Supervised Learning

Require: Successful trajectories $\mathcal{D}$; frozen language model Π_θ; pre-trained compressor $\mathcal{C}_\phi$

repeat
  Sample successful trajectory $\tau^* \sim \mathcal{D}$
  Initialize $\mathbf{Z}_1$
  $\mathcal{L}_{\text{BSL}} \leftarrow 0$
  for $t = 1, \ldots, T$ **do**
    $\widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}_t \leftarrow \mathcal{P}_\psi(\mathbf{Z}_t)$
    $\mathcal{L}_{\text{BSL}} \leftarrow \mathcal{L}_{\text{BSL}} - \log \Pi_\theta(a_t^* \mid \widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}_t, o_t)$
    Construct interaction h_t^*
    $\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_t \leftarrow \mathcal{F}_\omega(\mathbf{Z}_t)$
    $\mathbf{Z}_{t+1} \leftarrow \mathcal{C}_\phi\left(\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_t, h_t^*, \widehat{\mathbf{Z}}_{\text{inst}}\right)$
  end for
  $\Theta \leftarrow \Theta - \eta \nabla_\Theta \mathcal{L}$
until convergence
return Θ

Complete the task by interacting with the environment. At each step, reason about what you should do next and then issue one valid action.
Use the following format:
```
Thought: <reasoning>
Action: <environment action>
```

B.1.2 WEBSHOP

WebShop Prompt Template

Instruction
{shopping_instruction}
Observation
{current_webpage}
Find and purchase the product that best satisfies the user's request. At each step, reason about the current webpage and select one valid action.
Available actions include:
```
search[<query>]
click[<clickable item>]
```
Use the following format:
```
Thought: <reasoning>
Action: <valid action>
```

B.1.3 HOTPOTQA

HotpotQA Prompt Template

Question
{question}
Answer the question by gathering the necessary evidence. The question may require combining information from multiple sources.
At each step, either search for additional information or provide the final answer.
Use the following format:
```
Thought: <reasoning>
Action: Search[<query>]
```
or, when sufficient evidence has been collected,
```
Thought: <reasoning>
Action: Finish[<answer>]
```

Algorithm 3 GRPO Training

Require: Frozen language model Π_θ; BSL-initialized parameters Θ^*_{BSL}; group size G; clipping coefficient ε; TBPTT horizon M_{TBPTT}

repeat
  Sample task instance x
  $\Theta^{\mathrm{old}} \leftarrow \Theta$
  for $i = 1, \ldots, G$ **do**
    Initialize $\mathbf{Z}^{\mathrm{old}}_{i,1}$
    for $t = 1, \ldots, T_i$ **do**
      $\widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}^{\mathrm{old}}_{i,t} \leftarrow \mathcal{P}_{\psi^{\mathrm{old}}}(\mathbf{Z}^{\mathrm{old}}_{i,t})$
      Sample $a_{i,t} \sim \pi_\theta(\cdot \mid \widetilde{\mathbf{Z}}^{\mathrm{old}}_{i,t}, o_{i,t})$
      Execute $a_{i,t}$ and construct $h_{i,t}$
      if task terminates **then**
        break
      end if
      $\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}^{\mathrm{old}}_{i,t} \leftarrow \mathcal{F}_{\omega^{\mathrm{old}}}(\mathbf{Z}^{\mathrm{old}}_{i,t})$
      $\mathbf{Z}^{\mathrm{old}}_{i,t+1} \leftarrow \mathcal{C}_{\phi^{\mathrm{old}}}\left(\widehat{\mathbf{Z}}^{\mathrm{old}}_{i,t}, h_{i,t}, \widehat{\mathbf{Z}}^{\mathrm{old}}_{\mathrm{inst}}\right)$
    end for
    Obtain trajectory reward R_i
  end for
  $\mu_R \leftarrow \frac{1}{G}\sum_{i=1}^{G} R_i$
  $\sigma_R \leftarrow \sqrt{\frac{1}{G}\sum_{i=1}^{G}(R_i - \mu_R)^2}$
  for $i = 1, \ldots, G$ **do**
    $\hat{A}_i \leftarrow (R_i - \mu_R)/(\sigma_R + \delta)$
  end for
  Recompute $\mathbf{Z}^{\Theta_{\mathrm{GRPO}}}_{i,t}$ under current Θ_{GRPO} using TBPTT horizon M_{TBPTT}
  for all generated tokens $y_{i,t,l}$ **do**
    $p_{\mathrm{new}} \leftarrow \Pi_\theta(y_{i,t,l} \mid \mathcal{P}_\psi(\mathbf{Z}^{\Theta_{\mathrm{GRPO}}}_{i,t}), o_{i,t}, y_{i,t,<l})$
    $p_{\mathrm{old}} \leftarrow \Pi_\theta(y_{i,t,l} \mid \mathcal{P}_{\psi^{\mathrm{old}}}(\mathbf{Z}^{\mathrm{old}}_{i,t}), o_{i,t}, y_{i,t,<l})$
    $r_{i,t,l} \leftarrow p_{\mathrm{new}}/p_{\mathrm{old}}$
    $\mathcal{J}_{i,t,l} \leftarrow \min\left(r_{i,t,l}\widehat{A}_i,\ \mathrm{clip}(r_{i,t,l}, 1-\varepsilon, 1+\varepsilon)\widehat{A}_i\right)$
  end for
  $\mathcal{J} = \underset{i,t,l}{\mathrm{mean}}\left[\mathcal{J}_{i,t,l}\right]$
  $\Theta \leftarrow \Theta + \eta \nabla_\Theta \mathcal{J}$
until convergence
return Θ

TABLE 3: Training hyperparameters used in the main experiments.

Hyperparameter	Value
Optimizer	AdamW
Learning rate (BSL)	5e-5
Learning rate (RL)	1e-6
Weight decay	0.01
Training epochs	1
LR scheduler	Cosine
TBPTT length	8
GRPO group size	8
KL coefficient	0.04

B.2 MODELS

For the frozen language model, we use QWEN2.5-7B-INSTRUCT. For the pre-trained compressor, we use QWEN2.5-0.5B.

B.3 EVALUATION DETAILS

We run three independent trials and report the mean. For **HotpotQA**, we randomly sample 1500 instances instead of the full benchmark. We use greedy decoding for all evaluations.

B.4 IMPLEMENTATION AND TRAINING DETAILS

We run all the experiments on Google Colab using a single NVIDIA A100 80GB GPU. We implement the method using PyTorch and TRL. Table 3 lists our training hyperparameters.

B.5 BASELINES

For the sliding window baseline, we maintain the most recent 4 steps of information. For the summarization, we use the following prompt:

Summarization Prompt

Instruction: Summarize the interaction history below for the agent.
Preserve:

1. the task goal and constraints,
2. important observations and discovered information,
3. actions already taken and their outcomes,
4. current progress and state,
5. unresolved subgoals or remaining steps,
6. failures or actions that should not be repeated.

Remove redundant details and verbose reasoning. Do not add information that is not present in the history. Keep the summary concise but include enough information for the agent to continue the task without access to the original history.

Interaction History:
`{history}`
Summary: